

The Apology: Philosophical Context: The Three Periods of Plato's Dialogues - SparkNotes

Model

sourceFile: "The Apology: Philosophical Context: The Three Periods of Plato's Dialogues - SparkNotes"
exportedBy: "Kortex" exportDate: "2026-05-13T11:59:16.335Z"

The Apology: Philosophical Context: The Three Periods of Plato's Dialogues - SparkNotes

49aab70e-f1ef-40b1-ac1c-c75d4011495b

The Apology: Philosophical Context: The Three Periods of Plato's Dialogues - SparkNotes

905eb052-74a1-4d81-b8c1-dc49ee2a9f4b

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

The Apology: Philosophical Context: The Three Periods of Plato's Dialogues | SparkNotes

<https://www.sparknotes.com/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/>

Start free trial Log in

<https://www.sparknotes.com/lit/>

Shakespeare

<https://www.sparknotes.com/shakespeare/>

Other Subjects

<https://www.sparknotes.com/othersubjects/>

AP ® Test Prep PLUS

<https://www.sparknotes.com/test-prep/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/teacher/>

Teacher's Handbook

<https://www.sparknotes.com/teachers-handbook/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/blog/>

Sign Up for PLUS

My PLUS Dashboard

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard>

My PLUS Activity

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/notes>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/favorite-pages>

Test Prep PLUS

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/test-prep>

No Fear Translations & Audio

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/no-fear>

Mastery Quizzes

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/quizzes>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/flashcards>

Infographics

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/infographics>

No Fear Graphic Novels

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/graphic-novels>

Account Details

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/my-account>

Subscription & Billing

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/my-account/#billing-details>

Please wait while we process your payment

Reset Password

Send password reset email

Please wait while we process your payment

Get instant, ad-free access to our grade-boosting study tools with a 7-day free trial!

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Create Account

Continue with Google

<https://www.sparknotes.com/auth/google>

Looks like an account already exists for this email address! Please sign in, or create a new account with a different email address.

Please use a valid email address

Your password must:

Be between 8-15 characters.

Contain at least one capital letter.

Contain at least one number.

Be different from your email address.

Sorry, this password doesn't meet our criteria. Please check the password tip above and try again.

By signing up, I confirm that I or my legal guardian has read the

Privacy Policy

<https://bn.clarip.com/privacycenter/?brand=SPARKNOTES>

Kids' Privacy Notice

<https://www.sparknotes.com/kids-privacy-notice/>

and agrees to the

Terms of Service

<https://www.sparknotes.com/terms-of-use/>

Already have an account?

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

This site is protected by reCAPTCHA and the Google

Privacy Policy

<https://policies.google.com/privacy>

Terms of Service

<https://policies.google.com/terms>

Log into your PLUS account

Continue with Google

<https://www.sparknotes.com/auth/google>

Please enter your email and password.

Please use a valid email address

Your password must:

Be between 8-15 characters.

Contain at least one capital letter.

Contain at least one number.

Be different from your email address.

Sorry, this password doesn't meet our criteria. Please check the password tip above and try again.

Forgot Password?

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Don't have an account?

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Create Account

Select Plan

Payment Info

Start 7-Day Free Trial!

Select Your Plan

Group Discount

/month + tax

/year + tax

2-49 accounts

\$22.49/year + tax

50-99 accounts

\$20.99/year + tax

Select Quantity

Price per seat

29.99--.--

Select Annual Plan

Continue to Payment

Want 100 or more?

Request a customized plan

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

What's Included in the Plans?

/month + tax

You could save over 50%

by choosing an Annual Plan!

/year + tax

SAVE OVER 50%

compared to the monthly price!

| Focused-studying |

| --- | --- | --- |

Ad-free experience |

Study Guides for 1,000+ titles |

Full Text content for 250+ titles |

| PLUS Study Tools |

No Fear Translations of Shakespeare's plays (along with audio!) and other classic works |

Flashcards |

Mastery Quizzes |

Infographics |

Graphic Novels |

| AP® Test Prep PLUS |

AP® Practice & Lessons |

| My PLUS Activity |

Note-taking |

Bookmarking |

Dashboard |

\$22.49/month + tax

on 2-49 accounts

\$20.99/month + tax

on 50-99 accounts

| Focused-studying |

| --- | --- | --- |

Ad-free experience |

Study Guides for 1,000+ titles |

Full Text content for 250+ titles |

| PLUS Study Tools |

No Fear Translations of Shakespeare's plays (along with audio!) and other classic works |

Flashcards |

Mastery Quizzes |

Infographics |

[Graphic Novels |](#)

[| AP® Test Prep PLUS |](#)

[AP® Practice & Lessons |](#)

[| My PLUS Activity |](#)

[Note-taking |](#)

[Bookmarking |](#)

[Dashboard |](#)

[Testimonials from SparkNotes Customers](#)

No Fear provides access to Shakespeare for students who normally couldn't (or wouldn't) read his plays. It's also a very useful tool when trying to explain Shakespeare's wordplay!

I tutor high school students in a variety of subjects. Having access to the literature translations helps me to stay informed about the various assignments. Your summaries and translations are invaluable.

Teaching Shakespeare to today's generation can be challenging. No Fear helps a ton with understanding the crux of the text.

[Testimonials from SparkNotes Customers](#)

No Fear provides access to Shakespeare for students who normally couldn't (or wouldn't) read his plays. It's also a very useful tool when trying to explain Shakespeare's wordplay!

I tutor high school students in a variety of subjects. Having access to the literature translations helps me to stay informed about the various assignments. Your summaries and translations are invaluable.

Teaching Shakespeare to today's generation can be challenging. No Fear helps a ton with understanding the crux of the text.

[Create Account](#)

[Select Plan](#)

[Payment Info](#)

Start 7-Day Free Trial!

Payment Information

You will only be charged after the completion of the 7-day free trial.

If you cancel your account before the free trial is over, you will not be charged.

You will only be charged after the completion of the 7-day free trial. If you cancel your account before the free trial is over, you will not be charged.

Order Summary

7-day Free Trial

SparkNotes PLUS

\$29.99 / year

PLUS Group Discount

29.99 29.99 / seat

Total billed on Nov 7, 2024 after 7-day free trail

Total billed

This is not a valid promo code

Card Details

By checking this box, you confirm that you are 18 years old or above. If you are under 18, you are verifying that you will be supervised by a parent or legal guardian.

Sign up for the free PLUS newsletter

Save Payment Info and Start 7-Day Free Trial Save Payment Info & Start Free Trial

By placing your order, you confirm that you have read the

Privacy Policy

<https://bn.clarip.com/privacycenter/?brand=SPARKNOTES>

Kids' Privacy Notice

<https://www.sparknotes.com/kids-privacy-notice/>

and agree to the

Terms of Service

<https://www.sparknotes.com/terms-of-use/>

By saving your payment information you allow SparkNotes to charge you for future payments in accordance with their terms.

Powered by stripe

Google pay.....

Your group members can use the joining link below to redeem their membership. They will be prompted to log into an existing account or to create a new account. All members under 16 will be required to obtain a parent's consent sent via link in an email.

Manage Your Purchase Redeem a Code Now

Your Child's Free Trial Starts Now!

Thank you for completing the sign-up process. Your child's SparkNotes PLUS login credentials are

and the associated password. If you have any questions, please visit our help center

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Your Free Trial Starts Now!

Back to SparkNotes Explore PLUS Dashboard

Please wait while we process your payment

Parent's Email is Required

A parent must help manage your account. Enter their email below and we'll send them a link to finish signing up for SparkNotes PLUS.

Parent's email address

Sorry, you must enter a valid email address

By entering an email, I confirm that I or my legal guardian has read the
Privacy Policy

<https://bn.clarip.com/privacycenter/?brand=SPARKNOTES>

Kids' Privacy Notice

<https://www.sparknotes.com/kids-privacy-notice/>

and agrees to the

Terms of Service

<https://www.sparknotes.com/terms-of-use/>

Please wait while we process your payment

Email Sent Parent's Email is Required

We've sent an email to

parentsname@email.com

. In order to access SparkNotes PLUS, your parent must click the link provided in the email. We've sent an email to

parentsname@email.com

. In order to access SparkNotes PLUS, your parent must click the link provided in the email.

Resend Email Back to SparkNotes

Need to resend to a different parent's email?

Enter new parent's email address

Sorry, you must enter a valid email address

By entering an email, I confirm that I or my legal guardian has read the
Privacy Policy

<https://bn.clarip.com/privacycenter/?brand=SPARKNOTES>

Kids' Privacy Notice

<https://www.sparknotes.com/kids-privacy-notice/>

and agrees to the

Terms of Service

<https://www.sparknotes.com/terms-of-use/>

Search all of SparkNotes Search

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Recent Searches

Top Study Guides

The Great Gatsby

<https://www.sparknotes.com/lit/gatsby>

Lord of the Flies

<https://www.sparknotes.com/lit/flies>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/shakespeare/macbeth>

To Kill a Mockingbird

<https://www.sparknotes.com/lit/mocking>

Frankenstein

<https://www.sparknotes.com/lit/frankenstein>

Sign Up for PLUS

<https://www.sparknotes.com/lit/>

Shakespeare

<https://www.sparknotes.com/shakespeare/>

Other Subjects

<https://www.sparknotes.com/othersubjects/>

AP ® Test Prep PLUS

<https://www.sparknotes.com/test-prep/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/teacher/>

Teacher's Handbook

<https://www.sparknotes.com/teachers-handbook/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/blog/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/help>

My PLUS Activity

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/notes>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/favorite-pages>

AP ® Test Prep PLUS

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/test-prep>

No Fear Translations & Audio

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/no-fear>

Mastery Quizzes

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/quizzes>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/flashcards>

Infographics

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/infographics>

No Fear Graphic Novels

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/dashboard/graphic-novels>

Account Details

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/my-account>

Subscription & Billing

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/my-account/#billing-details>

Manage Group Discount

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/my-account/#manage-group>

Please wait while we process your payment

Your PLUS subscription has expired

We'd love to have you back! Renew your subscription to regain access to all of our exclusive, ad-free study tools.

Renew your subscription to regain access to all of our exclusive, ad-free study tools.

Renew your subscription

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus/my-account/#billing-details>

Please wait while we process your payment

Go ad-free AND get instant access to grade-boosting study tools!

Start your 7-day FREE trial now!

Please wait while we process your payment

Please Enter Your Date of Birth

SparkNotes requires all users to provide their real date of birth to comply with local laws.

Please read our

<https://www.sparknotes.com/terms-of-use/>

privacy policy

<https://bn.clarip.com/privacycenter/?brand=SPARKNOTES>

The Apology

](<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/>)

Study Guide

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/>

Study Guide

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/full-text/introduction/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/flashcards/>

Study Guide

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/>

Study Guide

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/full-text/introduction/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/flashcards/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/>

Key Terms & People

Deeper Study

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Sparklet Section Summaries

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/sparklets/>

Summary & Analysis

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Section 1: 17a - 18a

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/section1/>

Section 2: 18a - 20c

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/section2/>

Section 3: 20c - 24e

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/section3/>

Section 4: 24b - 28a

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/section4/>

Section 5: 28a - 32e

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/section5/>

Section 6: 32e - 35d

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/section6/>

Section 7: 35e - 38b

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/section7/>

Section 8: 38c - 42a

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/section8/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Full Work Summary

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/summary/>

Full Work Analysis

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/plot-analysis/>

Key Terms & People

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/key-terms/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/characters/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Socratic Irony as a Form of Humble Acceptance

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/idea-socratic-irony/>

The Elenchus and the Philosophical Process

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/idea-elenchus/>

The Socratic Claim Concerning the Nature of Evil

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/idea-nature-of-evil/>

Socrates's Supernatural Sign and His Relationship to the State

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/idea-supernatural/>

Deeper Study

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

About Socrates & Plato

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/context/>

Historical Context: Presocratic Philosophy, the Sophists, Socrates, and Plato

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/historical-context-sophism/>

Philosophical Context: The Three Periods of Plato's Dialogues

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Socrates's Assessment of the Wisdom of Politicians, Poets, & Craftsmen

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/context-wisdom/>

Socrates and the Ideal Philosopher

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/context-ideal-philosopher/>

What Socrates Means by “the unexamined life is not worth living”

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/mini-essays/>

Other Works by Plato on SparkNotes

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/related-works/>

Suggested Essay Topics

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/essay-topics/>

Please wait while we process your payment

Unlock your FREE SparkNotes PLUS trial!

Unlock your FREE Trial!

Sign up and get instant access to bookmarks.

Ad-Free experience

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

Easy-to-access study notes

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

Flashcards & Quizzes

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

AP® English test prep

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

Plus much more

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

Sign up to start your FREE trial Renew your subscription Already have an account?

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Deeper Study

The Apology Philosophical Context: The Three Periods of Plato's Dialogues

Philosophical Context: The Three Periods of Plato's Dialogues

Deeper Study The Apology Philosophical Context: The Three Periods of Plato's Dialogues

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/historical-context-sophism>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/context-wisdom>

Plato's dialogues are classified into early, middle, and late periods—with the works in each period having distinct characteristics that set them apart from the works in the other periods.

Early Plato, Elenchus, and

The Apology

The early dialogues, including

The Apology

, written soon after Socrates's death, provide the nearest portrayal of what Socrates's philosophy might have been. In these dialogues, Plato focuses almost exclusively on ethical questions, using the Socratic method of elenchus. In a typical early dialogue, Socrates asks his interlocutor for a definition of some virtue (piety, courage, etc.); once the definition is offered, he shows that the definition is inconsistent with other beliefs that the interlocutor holds. The interlocutor refines his definition, and Socrates shows that the new version is still inconsistent with other beliefs. This cycle of revisions and rebuttals is intended to continue until a satisfactory definition is reached, but this never actually happens in any of the dialogues. With the exception of a few key doctrines, no idea ever emerges from elenchus still looking tenable. A typical early dialogue ends in a state of aporia—intellectual gridlock, where all existing beliefs on the topic have been rebutted, but progress seems impossible. The interlocutors know what they thought before was wrong, but they are not told what to believe instead.

These dialogues should not be considered failures. According to Socrates, the goal of elenchus is not to reach definitions. He claimed that engaging in philosophic dialectic is crucial to human well-being—rendering people both happier and more virtuous. He believed this so strongly that, by some accounts, he chose to be executed rather than give up the practice. Though in the early dialogues Plato utilizes Socratic methods, he does not accept everything taught to him by Socrates. He explores many of these views critically, laying them out but not necessarily endorsing them.

The Apology

there is only one appearance of another speaker other than Socrates, Meletus (24b – 28a), and it is the only instance of the elenchus. Importantly, however,

The Apology

marks an interesting point in Plato's works because it represents an instance in which Socrates refers to Plato as his student by name. While most of the dialogues in Plato's other works are usually told by a third or fourth party who heard from a friend or acquaintance about a dialogue of Socrates' at which another friend was present,

The Apology

presents Socrates' words verbatim, without any framing devices to distance the narration. Plato in this case makes a particular effort to point out that he was actually present at Socrates' defense. The purpose here might be to lend the retelling a certain authenticity: the author was present at the trial, and has copied down Socrates' speech word for word. It would be important for Plato to be able to claim such authority, as he wishes to acquit Socrates posthumously as much as possible.

Middle Plato, Socrates, and the Theory of Forms

In the middle period, Plato develops a distinct voice and philosophical outlook. The figure of Socrates becomes more of a mouthpiece for Plato's own views. He relies less on the method of elenchus and presents his dialogues as conversation between a teacher and his students rather than as debate between a philosopher and his opponents. Instead of aporia, interlocutors arrive at positive conclusions. Ideas hinted at in the early dialogues, such as the theory of Forms, emerge as full-fledged doctrines. Plato's interests broaden beyond ethics into epistemology and metaphysics. He draws on his theory of Forms and the idea of the soul to explore old questions about how to live, the nature and role of love, and the nature of the physical world.

The Republic

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/republic/>

is paradigmatic of the shift from the early to middle periods. Book I adheres to the structure of a typical early dialogue. Some speculate that it originally stood on its own as a dialogue dating from the early period (in which case it would have been called

Thrasymachus

). Plato has Socrates use the method of elenchus in an attempt to pry out a definition of justice, and the result is aporia. Instead of leaving off there, Socrates picks up the question in Book II. He hashes out a detailed positive theory of justice over the course of nine more books. In these books, rather than employing the elenchus, Socrates mostly lectures, pausing intermittently to respond to objections raised by his students, Plato's two brothers. In Book VII, Socrates warns against elenchus. He declares that philosophical dialectic is dangerous in the wrong hands and should only be taught to the right people and only then when they are old enough to use it properly. He warns that those without the proper respect for truth would use the method in order to argue against everything instead of using it to seek out what is right. This discussion might explain what motivated Plato's shift in methods of inquiry and what motivated him to found the Academy.

Late Plato and Socrates' Views on Death

The later dialogues are extremely difficult and controversial. They contain Plato's most complex philosophical and logical views, and there is little agreement over what trends and themes define this period. One work among this later group is worth mentioning in relation to

The Apology

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/phaedo/>

, a more mature work that deals primarily with questions of the immortality of the soul.
An early work,

The Apology

centers more around Socrates' philosophical opinions, which, as he so persistently claims, are agnostic regarding any factual questions. In the later

, however, we see Socrates claiming to have positive knowledge of what happens after death. As for

The Apology

, Socrates concludes in typical manner, acknowledging that he does not, and cannot, know for certain what awaits him after death.

Previous section Historical Context: Presocratic Philosophy, the Sophists, Socrates, and Plato

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/historical-context-sophism>

Next section Socrates's Assessment of the Wisdom of Politicians, Poets, & Craftsmen

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/context-wisdom>

Did you know you can highlight text to take a note? x

The Apology (SparkNotes Philosophy Guide)

Ace your assignments with our guide to

The Apology

! BUY NOW](<http://www.barnesandnoble.com/w/the-apology-sparknotes/1119949493?ean=9781411473775>)

Notes See All Notes

Add Note with SparkNotes PLUS

The Apology

Add your thoughts right here!

Please wait while we process your payment

Unlock your FREE SparkNotes PLUS trial!

Unlock your FREE Trial!

Sign up and get instant access to creating and saving your own notes as you read.

Ad-Free experience

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

Easy-to-access study notes

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

Flashcards & Quizzes

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

AP® English test prep

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

Plus much more

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

Sign up to start your FREE trial Renew your subscription Already have an account?

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

Popular pages: The Apology

Full Work Analysis SUMMARY

](<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/plot-analysis/>)

People KEY TERMS & PEOPLE

](<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/characters/>)

Take a Study Break

18 of the Most Brilliant Lines of Foreshadowing in Literature

](<https://www.sparknotes.com/blog/18-of-the-most-brilliant-lines-of-foreshadowing-in-literature-2/>)

The 7 Most Messed-Up Short Stories We All Had to Read in School

](<https://www.sparknotes.com/blog/7-of-the-most-disturbing-short-stories-youll-ever-have-to-read-for-school/>)

21 Rejected Titles William Golding Considered Before Settling on

Lord of the Flies

](<https://www.sparknotes.com/blog/20-rejected-titles-william-golding-considered-before-settling-on-lord-of-the-flies/>)

QUIZ: Which Greek God Are You?

](<https://www.sparknotes.com/blog/which-greek-god-are-you/>)

Sign up for our latest news and updates!

By entering your email address you agree to receive emails from SparkNotes and verify that you are over the age of 13. You can view our

Privacy Policy here

<https://bn.clarip.com/privacycenter/?brand=SPARKNOTES>

. Unsubscribe from our emails at any time.

SparkNotes—the stress-free way to a better GPA

<https://www.sparknotes.com/lit/>

Shakespeare

<https://www.sparknotes.com/shakespeare/>

Other Subjects

<https://www.sparknotes.com/othersubjects>

AP ® Test Prep PLUS

<https://www.sparknotes.com/test-prep/>

Teacher's Handbook

<https://www.sparknotes.com/teachers-handbook>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/blog>

Premium Study Tools

SparkNotes PLUS

<https://www.sparknotes.com/plus>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/philosophy/apology/philosophical-context-three-periods/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/help/#sn-plus-about>

Helpful Resources

How to Cite SparkNotes

<https://www.sparknotes.com/writinghelp/citing/>

How to Write Literary Analysis

<https://www.sparknotes.com/writinghelp/how-to-write-literary-analysis/>

William Shakespeare's Life & Times

<https://www.sparknotes.com/shakespeare/life-and-times/>

Glossary of Shakespeare Terms

<https://www.sparknotes.com/shakespeare/life-and-times/shakespeares-language/a-glossary-of-common-shakespearean-words/>

Glossary of Literary Terms

<https://www.sparknotes.com/writinghelp/glossary-of-literary-terms/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/help/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/about/>

<https://www.sparknotes.com/contact/>

Copyright © 2026 SparkNotes LLC

Terms of Use

<https://www.sparknotes.com/terms-of-use/>

<https://bn.clarip.com/privacycenter/?brand=SPARKNOTES>

Kids' Privacy Notice

<https://www.sparknotes.com/kids-privacy-notice>

Cookie Policy

<https://www.barnesandnoble.com/h/help/cookie-policy>

Your Privacy Choices

javascript:void(0);

<https://x.com/sparknotes>

[https://www.instagram.com/sparknotes_ /](https://www.instagram.com/sparknotes_/)

<http://www.facebook.com/SPARKNOTES>

[https://www.tiktok.com/@sparknotes_ ?lang=en](https://www.tiktok.com/@sparknotes_?lang=en)

Barnes & Noble uses cookies to offer you a better user experience. By clicking “Accept All Cookies” you agree to the storing of cookies on your device in accordance with our

Cookie Policy

<https://www.barnesandnoble.com/h/help/cookie-policy>

Manage Preferences Reject All Cookies Accept All Cookies

Privacy Preference Center

Your Privacy

Your Privacy

When you visit any website, it may store or retrieve information on your browser, mostly in the form of cookies. This information might be about you, your preferences or your device and is mostly used to make the site work as you expect it to. The information does not usually directly identify you, but it can give you a more personalized web experience. Because we respect your right to privacy, you can choose not to allow some types of cookies. Click on the different category headings to find out more and change our default settings. However, blocking some types of cookies may impact your experience of the site and the services we are able to offer.

More information

<https://cookiepedia.co.uk/giving-consent-to-cookies>

Strictly Necessary Cookies

Strictly Necessary Cookies

Always Active These cookies are necessary for the website to function and cannot be switched off in our systems. They are usually only set in response to actions made by you which amount to a request for services, such as setting your privacy preferences, logging in or filling in forms. You can set your browser to block or alert you about these cookies, but some parts of the site will not then work. These cookies do not store any personally identifiable information.

Performance Cookies

Performance Cookies

[x] Performance Cookies These cookies allow us to count visits and traffic sources so we can measure and improve the performance of our site. They help us to know which pages are the most and least popular and see how visitors move around the site. All information these cookies collect is aggregated and therefore anonymous. If you do not allow these cookies we will not know when you have visited our site, and will not be able to monitor its performance.

Functional Cookies

Functional Cookies

[x] Functional Cookies These cookies enable the website to provide enhanced functionality and personalisation. They may be set by us or by third party providers whose services we have added to our pages. If you do not allow these cookies then some or all of these services may not function properly.

Targeting Cookies

Targeting Cookies

[x] Targeting Cookies These cookies may be set through our site by our advertising partners. They may be used by those companies to build a profile of your interests, to measure the effectiveness of marketing campaigns, and show you relevant adverts on other sites. They do not store directly personal information, but are based on uniquely identifying your browser and internet device. If you do not allow these cookies, you will experience less targeted advertising.

Cookie List

Consent Leg.Interest

checkbox label label

checkbox label label

checkbox label label

checkbox label label

Apply Cancel

Save Settings

Reject All Allow All